CHAPTER 10

CHANGE AND DEVELOPMENT IN INDUSTRIAL SOCIETY

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Examine industrial society in India, tracking division of labour, Taylorism and Fordism to flexible post-Fordism, the organized versus unorganized sectors, hazardous working environments, informalisation of labour, home-based production, and trade union politics.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Organization of Industrial Labour: Taylorism and Fordism:** Industrial manufacturing historically relied on Taylorism (scientific management via time-and-motion studies, de-skilling of workers) and Fordism (continuous conveyor assembly lines for mass production); post-Fordism introduced flexible manufacturing, subcontracting, and automation.

• **The Structural Divide: Organized versus Unorganized Sectors:** India exhibits severe industrial dualism: the organized sector (comprising registered enterprises with legal social security, job stability, and union rights) employs under 10 percent of the workforce, leaving over 90 percent in the unprotected unorganized sector.

• **Informalisation and Contractualization of Labour:** Liberalization and cost-cutting pressures have accelerated the informalisation of labour, wherein formal enterprises replace permanent workers with contract labour, hire third-party vendors, and fragment production into unregulated home-based piece-rate units.

• **Working Conditions and Industrial Conflict:** Unorganized industrial workers in coal mines, textile mills, and brick kilns face severe occupational hazards, low wages, and lack of safety standards; the historic 1982 Bombay Textile Strike highlighted both worker solidarity and the catastrophic consequences of state-backed corporate restructuring.

ESSENTIAL SOCIOLOGICAL CONCEPTS & INSTITUTIONS

$$\text{Workforce Dualism (India)} \rightarrow \{\text{Organized Sector: 7 to 9 Percent (Formal Benefits)}, \quad \text{Informal Sector: 90 Plus Percent (Precarious Work)}\}$$

Macro Structural Division of Subcontinental Employment

$$\text{Taylorist-Fordist Production} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Scientific Time-Motion Studies} + \text{Standardized Assembly Line} \rightarrow \text{Worker De-Skilling}$$

Classical Industrial Rationalization Paradigm

$$\text{Post-Fordist Flexibility} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Flexible Production Systems} + \text{Subcontracting} - \text{Core and Periphery Labour}$$

Contemporary Paradigm of Globalized Manufacturing

$$\text{Informalisation Dynamic} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Retrenchment of Permanent Staff} + \text{Contract Labour Deployment} \rightarrow \text{Depressed Union Leverage}$$

Mechanism of Corporate Labour Flexibilization

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** The unorganized sector is not confined to rural farming; it includes millions of urban manufacturing workers, home-based stitchers, construction labourers, and service providers.

• **Alert:** Taylorism was designed to maximize managerial control over the labour process by separating conception (planning by managers) from execution (routine physical tasks by workers), leading to extreme alienation.

• **Alert:** The 1982 Bombay Textile Strike, led by Dr. Datta Samant, involved nearly 250,000 workers; its defeat led to widespread mill closures, informalisation, and real estate redevelopment of mill lands.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Distinguish between the organized sector and the unorganized sector of employment in India. **[Score: 2 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Organized Sector:** Consists of registered enterprises employing 10 or more workers with regular salaries, fixed working hours, statutory social security (provident fund, gratuity, pensions), and legal union rights. **[1 Mark]**

• **Unorganized Sector:** Comprises small, unregistered units, casual day labourers, and home-based workers with no written job contracts, no paid leave, and no social security benefits. **[1 Mark]**

2. What is Taylorism? How did it alter the relationship between industrial workers and their work? **[Score: 3 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Concept:** A system of 'scientific management' invented by Frederick Winslow Taylor that breaks down every manufacturing task into timed, standardized physical motions to maximize worker speed and output. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Impact on Labour:** Stripped workers of intellectual initiative and craftsmanship, centralizing planning entirely in managerial hands, which caused severe alienation, fatigue, and de-skilling of the industrial proletariat. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. Compare Fordism with post-Fordism in terms of production methods, worker skills, and product flexibility. **[Score: 4 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Fordism:** Characterized by mass assembly-line production of standardized goods for uniform markets, full-time lifelong employment of semi-skilled workers, and strong trade unions. **[2 Marks]**

• **Post-Fordism:** Relies on flexible manufacturing systems, small-batch customized production, computer-aided design, outsourcing, and hiring contract workers to minimize corporate inventory and fixed wage overheads. **[2 Marks]**

4. What is meant by the 'informalisation of labour'? State three consequences of informalisation for industrial workers. **[Score: 4 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Definition:** The structural process whereby workers are pushed out of or denied formal organized employment, resulting in a growing share of the workforce in precarious, unprotected jobs. **[1 Mark]**

• **Three Consequences:**
- Loss of job security and constant threat of arbitrary retrenchment without compensation.
- Depressed wage rates and complete absence of health insurance, maternity benefits, and pensions.
- Severe erosion of trade union density and collective bargaining power. **[3 Marks]**

5. Describe the working conditions and occupational hazards faced by workers in the mining sector or brick kilns. **[Score: 4 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Underground Mining Hazards:** Miners face cave-ins, poisonous gas leaks, subterranean flooding, and permanent lung diseases (silicosis, pneumoconiosis) due to continuous inhalation of coal and silica dust. **[2 Marks]**

• **Brick Kiln Conditions:** Migrant families endure extreme thermal radiation, breathe toxic fumes from burning coal and tires, carry heavy loads on their heads, and live in makeshift roadside sheds lacking sanitary toilets and clean drinking water. **[2 Marks]**

6. Explain the piece-rate wage system and subcontracting in home-based industries such as bidi-rolling or garment making. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Subcontracting Network:** Large manufacturing corporations subcontract manual assembly or rolling to local contractors, who distribute raw materials (tendu leaves, tobacco, fabric) directly to women workers at home. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Piece-Rate Wages:** Workers are paid strictly per piece produced (e.g. per 1000 rolled bidis) rather than an hourly or daily wage, driving families to enlist children to work exhausting hours for bare survival. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Employer Advantage:** Factory owners avoid factory overhead costs, electricity bills, and statutory compliance with the Factories Act and labour laws. **[1 Mark]**

7. Discuss the significance and outcome of the historic 1982 Bombay Textile Strike in the history of the Indian labour movement. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Mass Mobilization:** Led by Dr. Datta Samant, nearly 250,000 textile mill workers across Bombay went on strike demanding wage parity with chemical and engineering workers and genuine union recognition. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Prolonged Stalemate and Defeat:** The strike lasted over eighteen months; mill owners and the state refused to compromise, using police repression to break the strike. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Long-Term Structural Impact:** Dozens of historic textile mills closed down permanently, over 100,000 workers were displaced into informal street vending, and prime mill lands (Girangaon) were redeveloped into luxury malls and skyscrapers. **[1 Mark]**